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The World Isn't FLAT

India's exports take a hit as developed countries exhibit a fierce tendency to protect their domestic industry and ensure consumer health and safety

By Nivedita Mukherjee

Imagine a consignment of grapes being stopped at the US border because Americans think these are not safe enough for human consumption, tea shipments to the US getting registered under its Bio Terrorism Act, and shirts and skirts dispatched to Europe being checked to see if description on the labels are in the font specified by the authorities. Or Europeans refusing to sell Indian whisky as whisky in their markets. Or on a more sober note, companies not

adhering to a desired level of corporate social responsibility facing a ban from Western corporates.

Well, this may sound like episodes straight out of Ripley's *Believe It or Not*, but international trade has just got a little more complex, and perhaps bizarre, with protectionist practices now resurgent all over the world. The provocation? Tariffs have fallen and the economic slowdown has rattled economies and developed countries feeling vulnerable need to erect protective walls to save their industries and jobs.

On the face of it, these are innocuous moves serving legitimate concerns of nations. The truth is these are non-tariff barriers (NTBs), instruments to be wielded at whim to protect domestic producers. So a clutch of developed countries are raining NTBs in all shapes and sizes—technical barriers to trade (TBT) which includes packaging, markings, trademark and labelling requirements as well as procedures for assessing conformity to standards, or sanitary and phytosanitary standards (SPS) relating to food safety and animal-borne diseases. A